

World in Brief: Venezuela earthquakes death toll tops 900; Iran hits American military sites



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Close to 2,000 international emergency responders and over 100 search dogs have been deployed to **Venezuela**, as the death toll from Wednesday's [earthquakes](#) rose to at least 920. More than 3,300 are injured. Rescuers continue to search through the rubble of hundreds of collapsed buildings. The two quakes were the country's largest—and possibly deadliest—in over a century.

Iran said that it had attacked several American military sites in the Middle East in retaliation for earlier American strikes. The Americans hit several targets in Iran on Friday after an Iranian assault on a Singapore-flagged cargo ship in the Strait of Hormuz the day before. Prior to Iran's latest blitz, J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, warned that "violence will be met with violence".

The Trump administration allowed **Anthropic** to release Mythos 5, one of its latest AI models, to about 100 "trusted partners", including companies and government agencies. This month the administration told the AI lab to prevent foreigners using its most powerful models, prompting Anthropic to [block access](#). OpenAI said it would also launch its GPT 5.6 series to a "small group" at the request of the American government.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine's** president, said his country's missiles hit an industrial complex in Volgograd, in south-west **Russia**, which Ukrainian armed forces claimed makes weapons components. This week Mr Zelensky ordered 40 days of [intense strikes](#) on Russia in an attempt to pressure Vladimir Putin to end the war. Ukrainian drones have penetrated deep into Russia; in recent days they have hit refineries with dramatic effect.

France said it is evaluating reciprocal measures after **Burkina Faso** severed diplomatic ties. Burkina Faso, a former French colony, accuses France of supporting “terrorists” and “subversive networks” in the [West African country](#). France has denied the allegations. In a statement, France's foreign ministry said it regretted Burkina Faso's “hostile and unfounded decision” and advised French nationals in the [military state](#) to “exercise heightened vigilance”.

Australia will double the maximum penalty for companies failing to enforce its under-16 [social-media ban](#) to around A\$99m (\$68m) as it accused platforms of not complying with the rules. Tech firms have deactivated more than 5m profiles since the ban took effect in December. However there are still “too many children on social media”, the country's prime minister, Anthony Albanese, said.

Cape Verde, an island nation of around 500,000 people, became the smallest country to advance past the group stage of a football **World Cup**. Belgium, France and Senegal are also through after dominant performances against New Zealand, Norway and Iraq, respectively. Other teams progressing to the knockout stage, following wins this week, include Ivory Coast, the Netherlands and Spain. Germany also advanced, despite an unexpected 2-1 loss to Ecuador.

Word of the week: “Soul doc”. The nickname for Claude's 78-page constitution of rules and principles at Anthropic. Read about the [work of philosophers](#) at the AI lab.

*How well do you know the week's news? Test your knowledge with
our [quiz](#).*

Venezuela's desperate search for survivors



Photograph: Getty Images

Anger is flaring in Venezuela in the aftermath of [two powerful earthquakes](#) that struck Caracas, the capital, and La Guaira, on the north coast, on Wednesday. At least 920 people have been confirmed dead and 50,000 are reported missing. A 72-hour rescue window, the critical period for saving lives, closes on Saturday. The state has largely failed to send well-equipped personnel to the worst-affected areas, leaving Venezuelans to search the wreckage themselves. More than a dozen countries, including Colombia and the United States, both home to many of Venezuela's 8m-strong diaspora, have sent help.

More than a decade of economic chaos and corruption have compounded Venezuela's tragedy. The earthquake-prone country lacks an official warning system. Despite building codes developed after a devastating quake in 1967, some 250 buildings were severely damaged. Venezuela's severely indebted government will draw \$200m in emergency funds from the IMF to fund reconstruction. But with damage expected to total billions, that is nowhere near enough.

Is easyJet heading for a break-up?



Photograph: Alamy

This week easyJet, one of Europe's biggest low-cost airlines, [rejected a fourth takeover proposal](#) from Castlelake, calling its offer of £4.9bn (\$6.5bn) too cheap. But it agreed to give the American investment firm limited access to commercial information in the hope of securing a better deal. Under Britain's takeover rules, Castlelake has until next Sunday to make another bid.

The airline business has had a turbulent year. The Iran war sent jet-fuel prices soaring and weaker demand for European holidays has hit profits. Still, easyJet's assets may be attractive to its bidder at a time when new planes are in short supply. It owns around 200 aircraft and has orders for hundreds more. EasyJet also controls valuable landing slots at big European airports and has built a profitable package-holiday business. Investors may be tempted by a higher offer. Yet dismantling the airline would be a complex and risky undertaking in an industry where winds rapidly change.

The Vatican's extraordinary talkfest



Photograph: Getty Images

On Saturday [Pope Leo](#) concludes two days of discussion in the Vatican with cardinals of the Roman Catholic church, in a gathering known as an extraordinary consistory. (The ordinary kind are largely ceremonial). Before Leo was elected cardinals had appealed for greater collaboration with the papacy. The American pontiff has now convened two extraordinary consistories—as many as his predecessor, Francis, called in his 12-year papacy.

The most topical discussion will probably be on the theory of “just war”. Weeks into the Iran conflict, Leo argued in a social-media post that God was never on the side of “those who once wielded the sword and today drop bombs”. In response J.D. Vance, America’s vice-president, said Leo should be “careful” when opining on matters of theology. The pope subsequently wrote, in his first encyclical, [Magnifica Humanitas](#), that the whole notion of just war was “outdated”. Leo did not publicly explain his reasoning. But he may have done so behind closed doors this weekend.

Life, liberty and Larry David



Photograph: John Johnson/HBO

As an actor, Larry David does not possess great range. For 25 years on “Curb Your Enthusiasm”, an [HBO show](#) that he created, he played a character named Larry David, who shared a biography with his creator. He was petty, querulous, obnoxious, argumentative, dishonest and very funny.

On “Life, Larry and the Pursuit of Unhappiness”, another HBO show he has created, he plays various characters from American history. But the joke is that he is always Larry David: petty, querulous etc. As a soldier, he tries to weasel out of an obligation to deliver a fellow soldier’s letter to a girlfriend back home; as Alexander Graham Bell, he throws his new invention in the bin, enraged at the banality of telephone conversations; as a Founding Father, he includes having to share umbrellas among the grievances in his draft of the Declaration of Independence (which, he boasts, only took “two quills” to write). If you like Mr David, you’ll like this show; if not, eh, watch something else.

Weekend profile: Andy Burnham, Britain's prime minister-in-waiting



Photograph: Getty Images

A fun way of thinking about British prime ministers is to imagine what they would do if they were not running the country. Sir Keir Starmer, [who quit mid-term](#) on June 22nd, would probably be a lawyer, as he was before entering politics—although it is possible to imagine him as a hygiene inspector. Boris Johnson might be an airline boss or the owner of a football team. David Cameron, with his quick wit and smooth demeanour, would surely be a public-relations executive. But [Andy Burnham](#), who will almost certainly replace Sir Keir, would only ever be a politician.

That is not because Mr Burnham has always been a politician, although this is nearly true. He became an MP a quarter-century ago, rising into the cabinet during the final, doomed years of the New Labour era. He tried to become party leader in 2010, but failed. A second attempt in 2015 fared little better. In 2017 he took a newly invented job as mayor of Greater Manchester, which was the making of him.

The real reason why it is so hard to imagine Mr Burnham doing anything else is that he seems to enjoy politics so much. He likes meeting people; he likes talking; he likes persuading. His job rarely seems to get him down. People like meeting Mr Burnham, too. Americans sometimes talk about the “beer question”: which

politician would you rather have a pint with? By that measure, Mr Burnham would trounce almost anyone.

He does not relish making decisions, however—especially the kind that will leave one side angry. His last job was perfect for him, because the mayor of Greater Manchester has few formal powers. He spent a decade as a convenor, a negotiator and a cheerleader, rather than as a chief executive. Even so, he managed to make some poor choices, insisting that “green belt” land be preserved and stepping back from a clean-air scheme that would have angered motorists.

Mr Burnham’s political philosophy is similar to Sir Keir’s, not least in being vague. Both men sit somewhere near the middle of the Labour Party, putting them substantially to the left of the country. Both believe deeply in righting wrongs, especially those inflicted by the state. Mr Burnham has a crowd-pleasing streak, which could help him compete with the populist parties that menace Labour: the Greens and Reform UK. Like the current prime minister, he has yet to set out a convincing plan to fix Britain. But his leadership is going to look and feel very different.

Mini crossword

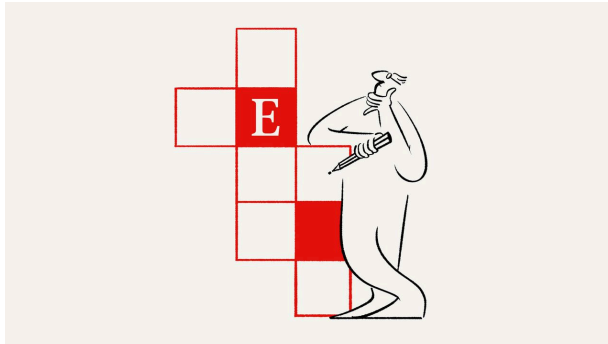


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - City that's attractively formed has humble beginning (5)

2 across - Poor cat eats sea creature (4)

3 across - Give up profit (5)

1 down - Holy hippo's revolutionary ideology (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Found in Scotland and Western Australia (5)

2 across - Toothed whale (4)

3 across - Total amount of a crop (5)

1 down - Its branches include aesthetics and logic (10)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nyna Hill, Ladysmith, BC, Canada

Tim Orwick, Denver, America

Mal Sudhakar, Bangalore, India

They all gave the correct answers of: Leo, Connie Francis, Benedict Cumberbatch, John Paul Getty senior and John Paul Jones. The theme is the last five Popes: Leo XIV, Francis, Benedict XVI, John-Paul II and John-Paul I.

The questions were:

Monday: Those born between July 23 and August 22 are generally associated with which Zodiac sign?

Tuesday: The singer Concetta Rosa Maria Franconero went under which stage name?

Wednesday: Which actor rose to fame playing a modern version of Sherlock Holmes before playing Dr Strange in various Marvel movies?

Thursday: Which American oil tycoon haggled with the kidnappers when his grandson was taken in 1973?

Friday: Which British-born officer is generally regarded as the “father of the American Navy” for his exploits in the Revolutionary war?

*One can never consent to creep
when one feels an impulse to soar.*

Helen Keller